'Right to return' The right of Palestinian refugees and their descendants to return to their pre-1948 homes in Israel and the occupied territories.

Secular Not religious or spiritual: a secular state is one not based on religion.

Settlement A group of houses, as built by the Israelis on the West Bank and in Gaza.

Shah The title of the King or Emperor of Iran. It is similar to Tsar, the name of the Russian monarch, or Kaiser, the German emperor.

Soviet Union The name by which communist Russia was known from 1917 to 1991. Its official name was the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR).

Stern gang A Zionist terrorist group founded in 1939.

Synagogue A building where Jews worship.

Taliban An Islamic movement, whose leaders were drawn from the former *mujahideen*, which took control of the Afghan government in 1996.

'The axis of evil' A phrase used by US President Bush to describe the link he saw between the states that he regarded as enemies.

Trade sanctions A form of punishment where the UN bans a country from trading with other countries in order to force it to obey a UN resolution.

UN General Assembly The main body of the UN in which every state is represented.

United Arab Republic The union of Egypt and Syria formed in 1958.

United Nations Security Council The most important body in the UN, it can take action against a country either by imposing sanctions or by using UN troops.

UNSCOM UN special committee set up to search for and destroy Iraq's WMD.

Vietnam The USA had a large military force fighting against communist North Vietnam and its communist allies in South Vietnam.

War of attrition A war in which each side tries to wear the other out.

Weapons of mass destruction (WMD) Biological, chemical or nuclear weapons, used to kill as many people as possible.

White Paper A government document making recommendations for discussion.

Yom Kippur Day of Atonement, an important Jewish religious day of fasting and an annual Jewish holiday.

Zionists Those who advocated the creation of a Jewish homeland and, later, an independent state, in Palestine.